

he took control of an amateur orchestra, the Christiania Philharmonic. His first major compositions date from this period. In 1867, he published the first volume of his *Lyric Pieces*, a collection of eight short pieces for solo piano. Often described as a miniaturist, Grieg specialized in brief, melodic compositions. Certainly, the *Lyric Pieces* were—and have remained—one of the most popular, and profitable, parts of his repertoire. He eventually published 10 volumes, containing a total of 66 pieces. The bulk of these compositions were produced in the 1880s and 1890s; the final volume appeared in 1901.

Grieg was also engaged in more sizeable projects. In 1868, he had completed the finest of his longer works, the Piano Concerto in A minor. This bears similarities to Schumann's Piano Concerto of 1845, which Grieg had heard performed by Clara Schumann in 1858, two years after her husband's death. In addition, to Schumann's influence, Grieg's concerto contained hints of a growing interest in folk material. The third movement carried echoes of the halling, an energetic folk dance from rural Norway. It also featured imitations of the traditional Hardanger fiddle (see [box](#)). Edvard had already learned about this from Ole Bull, who was something of a virtuoso on the instrument. The Hardanger fiddle had eight strings—twice as many as a standard violin—which made it easier for the violinist to perform a double stop (to play two notes simultaneously).